

Crimson topaz
Topaza pella

- ↔ 9 in (23 cm)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Common

The male crimson topaz is one of the most striking hummingbirds, with an iridescent crimson-purple breast and upperparts, a yellow-green throat, and a pair of long, dark tail feathers that curve in to cross over near their tips. The female is far less conspicuous, with mainly green plumage and a shorter tail. A denizen of tropical forests, the crimson topaz feeds in the middle and upper canopy, taking nectar from a wide variety of flowers. It is rarely seen on the ground.

Common swift
Apus apus

- ↔ 7 in (18 cm)
- 📍 N. and Southern Africa, Europe, W. to C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

A familiar summer sight in many northern towns, the common swift hunts in the air for small insects and carries them back to its young. But this is the only time the swift returns to a perch, for it is the most aerial of all birds—able to eat, drink, sleep, and even mate in flight.

- Other species
- **Booted racket-tail**
Ocreatus underwoodii » p88

Mousebirds
Order Coliiformes

Speckled mousebird
Colius striatus

- ↔ 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
- 📍 C., E., and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

This bird owes its name to the way it scrambles through vegetation like a mouse, searching for insects, flowers, and fruit. The effect is enhanced by its mainly brown plumage, although it has a very long, stiff tail. It often roosts in groups of up to 20, hanging together in a cluster from a branch.



Trogon
Order Trogoniformes

Violaceous trogon
Trogon violaceus

- ↔ 9–10 in (23–25 cm)
- 📍 SE. Mexico to C. South America
- ⊗ Common

The male violaceous trogon is dark blue and green above and yellow below, with black wings and a yellow eye-ring; the female, by contrast, is mostly gray. Usually

solitary, it lives in the rainforests of Amazonia and adjacent regions. The trogon usually nests in a tree hole, but may also use an old wasp or termite nest. It feeds on fruit, insects, and other invertebrates.

- Other species
- **Resplendent quetzal**
Pharomachrus mocinno » p81

Kingfishers and relatives
Order Coraciiformes

Common kingfisher
Alcedo atthis

- ↔ 7 in (18 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, N. Africa
- ⊗ Common



Mainly blue above, but with bright orange underparts, this short-tailed, heavy-billed bird can be surprisingly inconspicuous as it sits quietly on a perch overlooking the water, watching for prey. But when it spreads its wings, it reveals a vivid, electric-blue streak down its back, catching the eye as it skims across the water in fast, direct flight. It dives to seize small fish, returning to beat the victim against its perch before swallowing it head first. It supplements its diet with insects, crustaceans, and amphibians.

Southern yellow-billed hornbill
Tockus leucomelas

- ↔ 20–24 in (51–61 cm)
- 📍 Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

This long-tailed hornbill has a much smaller horny crest—or casque—than most hornbills. It has a bright red patch of naked skin around its eyes and on each side of its throat. Widespread on the savannas of

southern Africa, it forages on the ground for seeds, fruit, and insects, occasionally catching larger animals such as mice and even scorpions. It sometimes forms foraging parties with dwarf mongooses, which flush out locusts on which the birds feed. The hornbill, in turn, warns them of approaching danger.

Blue-crowned motmot
Momotus momota

- ↔ 19 in (48 cm)
- 📍 Central America to C. South America, Trinidad and Tobago
- ⊗ Common

Like many of its close relatives, this tropical forest bird has elongated central tail feathers that are bare except for the tips. It spends much of its time perched among the trees, barely moving

aside from slowly swinging its extended tail from side to side. It eats insects and spiders, gleaning them from tree trunks or the ground; it often immobilizes them by hitting them against a branch before swallowing them.



- Other species
- **Blue-winged kookaburra**
Dacelo leachii » p323
 - **European bee-eater**
Merops apiaster » pp150–51
 - **Great Indian hornbill**
Buceros bicornis » p264
 - **Hoopoe**
Upupa epops » p157
 - **Lilac-breasted roller**
Coracias caudatus » p207
 - **Red-billed hornbill**
Tockus erythrorhynchus » p206
 - **Stork-billed kingfisher**
Pelargopsis capensis » p299